

Guideline for Your Term Paper

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Term Paper Deadline: 6/15

- ▶ You should submit your term paper before 6/15
 - ▶ No late submission
 - ▶ Let me know if you want me to submit grade earlier
- ▶ Write your paper in Chinese or English
- ▶ You need to type your paper using **Latex**

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- ▶ **Please upload your paper before 11:59pm 6/15 using the following link**
 - ▶ <https://www.dropbox.com/request/aBeYTc1TAe2LUXbRj4VA>
 - ▶ Format of file name: studentID+name
 - ▶ Example: 1095323010_TzuTingYang

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- ▶ Letter style: roughly 2,000-3,000 words (less than 10 pages)
- ▶ The maximum number of exhibits (figures + tables) is five
 - ▶ See **Economics letters**
 - ▶ <https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/economics-letters>
 - ▶ <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0165176524001617>
 - ▶ <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0165176524001836>

Guideline for Writing a Term Paper

- ▶ Use credible causal inference methods to answer an empirical question
 - ▶ Test economics (social science) theory
 - ▶ Estimate policy effect
 - ▶ Any interesting questions regarding to human behavior/social phenomenon

Guideline for Writing a Term Paper

► The Typical Structure of an Empirical Paper

1 **Introduction/Motivation**

2 Literature Review

3 Theoretical Framework

4 **Data and Sample**

5 **Empirical Method**

6 **Results**

7 **Discussion and Conclusion**

Guideline for Writing a Term Paper

0 Title of the paper

- ▶ You need to give the title of your paper
- ▶ Use one sentence to summarize the research question you want to answer in this paper
- ▶
- ▶ The Effect of Financial Resource on Fertility: Evidence from Lottery Winners

1. Introduction/Motivation

- ▶ The question you are trying to address
 - ▶ Stating the hypothesis to be tested directly is a good way to do this
- ▶ Briefly state why we should care about this question
 - ▶ Is it an unproven theoretical result?
 - ▶ An important policy question or an interesting human behavior/social phenomenon?
- ▶ Briefly state how you answer this question
 - ▶ Empirical strategy you use to answer the question
 - ▶ What data you are using
- ▶ Briefly discuss your main findings and contributions
- ▶ **We usually finish “Introduction” in the end of project**

2. Literature Review

- ▶ The first section should discuss previous research that is **directly relevant to your paper**
 - ▶ Not every single paper written on the topic
- ▶ The second section should explain your contribution in more detail
- ▶ You should discuss how your approach is different from what has been done before
 - ▶ Answer a question more broadly/specifically
 - ▶ Use different data
 - ▶ Use different empirical strategy
 - ▶ Comparing how you are improving on a previous paper is useful
- ▶ You can combine introduction with literature review when you mention your contributions.

3. Theoretical Framework

- ▶ If your paper does not try to verify economics theory, you might not need this part
- ▶ Not every paper will require the development of a full theoretical model
- ▶ In the end, you need an empirical model, so the theoretical model you develop must lead somehow to what you are testing

4. Data and Sample

Data

- ▶ Describe the name and source of the data you are using and the period it covers
- ▶ Describe whether you have a panel, cross section or time series, what the unit of observation is and how many observations you have
- ▶ You may want to highlight the important limitations of this data

4. Data and Sample

Sample

- ▶ The second section should present (relevant) descriptive statistics of the estimated sample
- ▶ You should have a couple of tables with means and standard deviations for the variables you will be using in the analysis
- ▶ You may want to present these descriptive statistics for different subgroups

5. Empirical Method

- ▶ You should write down the basic econometric specification first and explain each of the variables and the parameters of interest
 - ▶ The model could be OLS, PDS, matching, IV, DID, RDD, SCM or others
 - ▶ Since IV, DID, RDD, and SCM can deal with unobserved confounding factors, these methods usually give us more credible results
- ▶ Discuss the identification assumption of your method.
- ▶ Discuss why this is the correct/best specification for the question you wish to address.
- ▶ Discuss why you want to control for certain variables

6. Results

- ▶ You should present results in a way that develops your argument step-by-step
 - ▶ For example, 1. main results; 2. break those results down by subgroups; 3. perform robustness checks
- ▶ Any tables with parameter estimates should clearly state which outcome variable you are using
- ▶ You should let readers know which control variables are included in your empirical models (put this information in table notes)
- ▶ Just discuss the most interesting and important estimates in your discussion of the table: **estimated causal effects**
- ▶ Make sure you report standard errors with your estimates in the tables
- ▶ Just look at some economics journals for a good table format

6. Results

- ▶ Interpret the magnitude of your parameter estimates in an economically meaningful way
 - ▶ For example, “we find that $b=0.3$, so that increasing X by one unit increases y by 0.3. The implied elasticity is...”
- ▶ **Graphical evidence is a very convincing way to show your reader that you have found something real**
 - ▶ Graphs are worth a thousand words
- ▶ Discuss whether the key estimates are statistically significant
 - ▶ Compare your results to what others have found
- ▶ **Don't worry if you don't find anything significant as long as your methods are credible and you have interpreted the results well**

7. Discussion and Conclusion

- ▶ Briefly summarize your findings
- ▶ Discuss some limitations in this paper
- ▶ Discuss your future plan about this project if you have more time and data